

The Longest Table

The street had not spoken to itself in twenty years.
Then someone put a table outside.

CEFR Level A2

Book 7 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: Ashton Road, a terraced street in a northern English city.

Genre: Community Drama / Warm Fiction

Characters

- Val — 66. Retired. Has lived on the street for thirty years. The instigator.
- Nico — 34. Moved in eight months ago. Italian-British. Works from home.
- Sunita — 48. Works long hours at the hospital. Three children.
- Mr. Okafor — 74. Nigerian-British. Has lived on the street longer than anyone.
- The teenagers at number seven — important minor characters.

It started with a power cut.

In February, a fault in the local grid knocked out electricity to the whole street for nine hours.

By six o'clock in the evening, six separate households were standing on their doorsteps with candles or torches, looking at each other for the first time in months.

Val, at number three, had cooked a large pot of soup on her gas hob before the power went out.

She brought it outside. Someone else brought bread. Someone else brought wine.

They ate on the pavement in the cold.

By eight o'clock, Val was thinking about summer.

A power cut. Soup on the pavement. And Val starts thinking about summer.

In April, Val put a handwritten note through every door on the street.

It said: I am proposing a street dinner on Saturday 14th July. One long table down the middle of the road.

Everyone brings something to eat. No charge, no tickets, no organising committee — just food and people.

If you're interested, put a note through my door by the end of April. If fewer than ten households say yes, I'll forget about it.

She got seventeen replies.

Nico had moved to Ashton Road eight months ago, after his relationship ended.

He worked from home — software development — and had barely spoken to anyone on the street.

When Val's note arrived, he read it twice. He almost didn't reply.

Then he thought about the power cut. About standing on the doorstep in the cold, eating soup with strangers. About how that had felt — unexpectedly normal.

He put a note through Val's door: I'll come. I can bring pasta.

Sunita had three children and worked four long days a week at the hospital.

When Val's note arrived, she left it on the kitchen table for a week.

It was her eldest daughter, Preet, who finally put the reply note in an envelope.

'Mum, just say yes,' Preet said. 'It's a street dinner. Not a commitment to anything.'

'Everything is a commitment to something,' Sunita said. But she let Preet post the note.

She said yes. She planned to bring a large dish of rice and dal.

Mr. Okafor had lived at number twenty-two for thirty-four years.

He had watched the street change — families come and go, shops open and close.

He did not reply to Val's note immediately. He sat with it for several days.

When Val came to his door in person, he opened it and said: 'I was going to say yes. I was just thinking about what to bring.'

'What have you decided?' Val asked.

'Jollof rice,' Mr. Okafor said. 'My wife's recipe. She's been gone twelve years. It's time it was shared.'

On the Friday before the dinner, Val walked the street counting houses and estimating numbers.

She had borrowed six trestle tables from the community centre and arranged for the council to issue a temporary road closure permit.

The Longest Table



A power cut makes the street notice itself again.

Nico had offered to help set up, which surprised Val slightly.

'You seem quite organised,' Val said.

'I'm a software developer,' Nico said. 'This is just a project. A live project with food.'

Val laughed. 'That's exactly what it is,' she said.

The 14th of July was warm and overcast — not too hot, which was ideal.

By eleven in the morning, Nico and Val had assembled the tables in a long row down the centre of the road.

By one o'clock, people were starting to come out.

The food appeared as if from nowhere — from dozens of kitchens on both sides of the street.

Jollof rice. Pasta salad. Dal. Samosas. A massive chocolate cake from the teenagers at number seven.

Two loaves of sourdough from the quiet couple at number twelve.

Wine. Lemonade. Someone brought a box of Coronation chicken, which they apologised for.

By three o'clock, sixty-three people were sitting or standing along the table.

This was remarkable because the street had forty-one houses.

'Where are the extras coming from?' Nico said to Val.

'Relatives,' Val said. 'Friends. I did say everyone should bring people.'

At the far end of the table, Mr. Okafor was talking to a young couple who had moved in six weeks ago and had not yet met anyone.

Sunita's youngest daughter was sitting on the wall with the teenagers from number seven.

Sunita herself was sitting for the first time that day.

Val brought Sunita a glass of wine and sat next to her.

'You're the nurse, aren't you?' Val said.

'Midwife,' Sunita said. 'Almost the same hours, though.'

Val looked down the table. 'Do you know many people here?'

'Almost no one,' Sunita said. 'I recognise faces. But I don't know names.'

'That's true for most of us,' Val said. 'I've lived here thirty years and I only know about half of them properly.'

'Properly is a high bar,' Sunita said.

'Neighbourly is lower,' Val said. 'You just have to know their name and wave.'

Nico had heard about Mr. Okafor's jollof rice and had gone to the end of the table to try it.

They ended up talking for an hour.

Mr. Okafor had worked as an engineer for forty years. He had built things across three continents.

Nico told him about his software work — infrastructure code, mostly.

'Building things invisibly,' Mr. Okafor said.

'Exactly,' Nico said. He had never heard it described that way before. 'That's exactly what it is.'

Mr. Okafor refilled his plate. 'The rice is better the second day, in my opinion. But today is all right.'

The teenagers at number seven were four of them — aged between fifteen and seventeen — and they had made a chocolate cake.

They had also made a playlist, which they played through a bluetooth speaker at a volume that was just below complaining level.

Their mother stood near them looking anxious.

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Val proposes one long table down the middle of the road.

At five o'clock, one of the teenagers — a tall boy named Marcus — got up and asked if anyone wanted more water.

He walked the length of the table, refilling glasses.

Val watched him. 'He's going to be all right,' she said to no one in particular.

By seven o'clock, the afternoon had turned warm and golden.

Some people had gone home — children to bed, early shifts to prepare for.

But about thirty people remained, and the atmosphere had changed from a organised gathering to something more informal.

Someone produced a guitar. Not very well played, but not discouraging.

Mr. Okafor told a story about a road he had helped build in Nigeria in 1983 — a story that took twenty minutes and was worth every one.

Nico translated quietly for the couple next to him, who had not followed every word.

Near nine o'clock, Val and Nico were folding tablecloths.

'Thank you for your help today,' Val said.

'I needed it,' Nico said. He said it simply, as a fact.

Val looked at him. 'How long have you been here now?'

'Eight months.' 'Settled in?' 'Not really. But today was — it helped.'

'This is what a street can do,' Val said. 'If it tries.'

'Does it always take a disaster to start it?' Nico said.

'The power cut. Without that, would you have done this?'

Val thought. 'Maybe not. But the power cut didn't make us neighbours. We were already neighbours. It just reminded us.'

Sunita's three children had scattered across the street during the afternoon.

Preet, the eldest, had spent most of the day helping — carrying dishes, clearing plates, refilling jugs.

Her middle child had made two new friends from the street and was still riding a bicycle with them at eight o'clock.

Her youngest was asleep on a deckchair at the end of the table.

Sunita looked at all three of them.

She thought: I should come outside more. That was all. Just that.

By ten o'clock, the tables were cleared and folded.

The road was surprisingly clean — the teenagers from number seven had swept it without being asked.

Val stood at her door and watched the last people go in.

Nico came to return the borrowed tablecloths.

'Same time next year?' he said.

Val looked at him. Then at the street.

'Same time next year,' she said.

Nico nodded and went home. He did not check his emails that evening.

Instead he sat in his flat and ate leftover pasta and felt, for the first time in eight months, like he lived somewhere.

The week after the dinner, small things changed on Ashton Road.

People nodded to each other in the street. Some actually stopped and spoke — briefly, about nothing important, but still.

Mr. Okafor waved at Sunita's youngest from his front step when she walked past on the way to school.

The Longest Table



The street dinner turns strangers into neighbours.

Nico found a bag of tomatoes on his doorstep on Wednesday — no note. He suspected Mr. Okafor, who had a garden.

He put a note through Mr. Okafor's door: Thank you for the tomatoes. And for the jollof rice.

Mr. Okafor replied: The tomatoes are nothing. But the rice you will not get again until next July.

By November, some of the changes had held.

Val had started a small street WhatsApp group — not for organising things, just for noticing things.

Someone reported a broken streetlight. Someone else flagged a suspicious car. Marcus from number seven asked if anyone wanted a car washed.

Most conversations were short. But the group existed.

Sunita had exchanged phone numbers with Val. Not for emergencies exactly — just in case.

Nico had been to Mr. Okafor's for tea twice.

These were small things. But they were not nothing.

In December, Val sat in her front room and thought about the year.

The power cut in February. The note in April. The dinner in July.

She was not someone who made plans — not usually.

But she thought about the nine hours in the cold with soup on the pavement, and she thought: that was something real. Why can't we do that again?

Most of the time, she knew, the answer was: life. Work. Exhaustion. Children. Fear of being turned down.

'Fear of being turned down,' she said aloud to her cat.

The cat ignored her.

'Seventeen people said yes,' she said.

"Seventeen people said yes." Fear stops us. But more often than we think, people say yes.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. power cut	elektrik kesintisi
2. grid	elektrik şebekesi
3. doorsteps	kapı önleri
4. torches	el fenerleri
5. gas hob	gazlı ocak
6. pavement	kaldırım
7. proposing	öneriyor
8. organising committee	organizasyon komitesi
9. households	haneler
10. handwritten note	el yazısıyla yazılmış not
11. reply	yanıt
12. no charge	ücretsiz
13. software development	yazılım geliştirme
14. barely	neredeyse hiç
15. unexpectedly	beklenmedik şekilde
16. normal	normal
17. relationship ended	ilişkisi bitti
18. eldest daughter	en büyük kız
19. commitment	taahhüt, yükümlülük
20. envelope	zarf
21. dish	yemek, tabak
22. dal	mercimek yemeği
23. post the note	notu postalamak
24. recipe	tarif
25. immediately	hemen
26. in person	bizzat
27. come and go	gelip gitmek
28. shared	paylaşıldı
29. several days	birkaç gün
30. estimating	tahmin etmek
31. trestle tables	sehpa masaları
32. road closure	yol kapanması
33. permit	izin
34. arranged for	ayarladı
35. organised	organize
36. overcast	bulutlu
37. assembled	kurdu
38. ideal	ideal

39. sourdough	ekşi mayalı ekmek
40. apologised for	... için özür diledi
41. remarkable	dikkat çekici
42. extras	fazladan gelenler
43. relatives	akrabalar
44. far end	uzak uç
45. youngest daughter	en küçük kız
46. sitting for the first time	ilk kez oturuyordu
47. midwife	ebe
48. recognise	tanımak
49. properly	düzgünce
50. high bar	yüksek standart
51. neighbourly	komşuca
52. wave	el sallamak
53. ended up talking	konuşmaya devam etti
54. infrastructure	altyapı
55. continents	kıtalar
56. invisibly	görünmez şekilde
57. refilled	doldurdu
58. in my opinion	bence
59. playlist	çalma listesi
60. bluetooth speaker	bluetooth hoparlör
61. complaining level	şikayet edilecek seviye
62. anxious	endişeli
63. refilling glasses	bardakları doldurmak
64. no one in particular	kimseye özellikle
65. atmosphere	atmosfer
66. informal	gayri resmi
67. gathering	buluşma
68. produced a guitar	gitarı çıkardı
69. discouraging	cesaret kırıcı
70. translated	tercüme etti
71. folding tablecloths	masa örtülerini katlıyor
72. settled in	yerleşti
73. disaster	felaket
74. reminded	hatırlattı
75. already	zaten
76. scattered	dağıldı

77. carrying dishes	tabakları taşıdı
78. jugs	sürahiler
79. deckchair	şezlong
80. asleep	uyuyor
81. come outside more	daha fazla dışarı çıkmak
82. swept it	süpürdü
83. leftover	artık yemek
84. surprisingly clean	şaşırtıcı şekilde temiz
85. return	iade etmek
86. felt like he lived	somewhere
87. nodded to each other	birbirine başını salladı
88. suspected	şüphelendi
89. briefly	kısaca
90. put a note through	not attı
91. walked past	yanından geçti
92. flagged	bildirdi
93. suspicious car	şüpheli araç
94. exchanged phone	numbers
95. emergencies	acil durumlar
96. existed	mevcut
97. exhaustion	yorgunluk, tükenme
98. turned down	reddedilmek
99. aloud	sesli olarak
100. ignored	yok saydı
101. usually	genellikle
102. real	gerçek

After-Reading Activities

Page 19 — The Second Year

The second annual dinner was on the 13th of July.

This time, twenty-three households said yes.

Mr. Okafor made his jollof rice again. Marcus, now eighteen, had taken over the music.

Nico had made a spreadsheet to coordinate the food — with Val's permission and mild amusement.

Sunita came an hour earlier than the year before.

She brought the dal and also, for the first time, she brought her sister.

'She lives on the next street,' Sunita told Val. 'She's been wanting to meet you.'

Val smiled. 'Bring the whole next street,' she said.

Vocabulary Support

annual

yıllık

coordinate

koordine etmek

mild amusement

hafif eğlence

spreadsheet

tablo, çizelge

permission

izin

next street

komşu sokak

Twenty-three households. The next street. The dinner is growing.

Page 20 — Ashton Road

By the third July, the street had a reputation.

People on other streets asked about it. A local newspaper sent a reporter.

Val refused to be photographed. 'This isn't about

me,' she said. 'This isn't even a story. It's just people eating outside.'

The reporter wrote about it anyway.

The article said: One street remembered how to be a street.

Val read it and thought: that's too grand.

Then she thought: but also, that's right.

She put the article in a drawer. She didn't show it to anyone.

On Ashton Road, the table was already being set up for the fourth time.

Vocabulary Support

reputation

itibar

reporter

muhabir

refused

reddetti

photographed

fotoğraflandı

article

makale, haber

grand

büyük, görkemli

"One street remembered how to be a street." Val thinks it's too grand. She's right. And wrong.

Answer Key

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. power cut

A. taahhüt

2. commitment

B. elektrik kesintisi

3. proposal

C. komşuca

4. neighbourly

D. öneri

5. infrastructure

E. altyapı

6. exhaust

F. tükenmek

7. annual

G. yıllık

8. reputation

H. itibar

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

power — yes — reminded — nowhere — nothing — outside

1. The idea started during a _____ cut that lasted nine hours.

2. The food appeared as if from _____ — from dozens of kitchens.

3. Val said the power cut didn't make them neighbours — it just _____ them.